

A FILM BY SYED ASAD RAZA ABIDI

PORTRAIT OF LIFE

PERFECTION FADES, BUT TRUE ART REMAINS.

PAKISTAN · URDU · 11 MIN · 1.33:1

2025

THE STORY

LOGLINE & SYNOPSIS

LOGLINE

A painter obsessed with capturing his wife perfectly blames her for every ruined canvas — until he understands that the flaw he keeps painting over is his own.

SHORT SYNOPSIS

A struggling painter, consumed by his need to create perfect art, blames his wife for his failures. But as he digs deeper, he realises his paintings are not about perfection — they are a reflection of his imperfect life, forcing him to face the cracks in their relationship and within himself.

FULL SYNOPSIS

Ayan, a painter, works and reworks the same portrait of his wife and cannot make it come out right. The likeness is there; something else is not. His frustration hardens into accusation — he tells her that the fault is in her, that something is missing in the woman in front of him, and that this is why the canvas keeps failing.

Zara meets his anger with patience. Paint from the heart, she tells him, not from the idea of perfection you are carrying. He cannot hear it. As the work stalls, the tension between them widens into something neither of them names out loud, and the marriage begins to bend under the weight of a painting that will not resolve.

Forced into stillness, the painter turns inward. Memories of childhood surface — the first time he picked up a brush, the loose and fearless work of a boy who had never once considered whether a line was correct. In that recollection he finds what his adult discipline has been quietly destroying.

He returns to the easel changed. The painting he finally makes is not perfect, and it is not meant to be. It is honest, and it is his, and for the first time in a long time he loves the making of it.

REFERENCE

FACT SHEET

TITLE	Portrait of Life
TAGLINE	Perfection fades, but true art remains.
PROJECT TYPE	Short film · Student project
GENRES	Romance · Drama · Art · Art Film
RUNTIME	11 minutes 34 seconds
COMPLETION DATE	2 June 2025
COUNTRY OF ORIGIN	Pakistan
COUNTRY OF FILMING	Pakistan
LANGUAGE	Urdu
SHOOTING FORMAT	Digital cinema camera — Sony FX3
ASPECT RATIO	1.33:1
FILM COLOUR	Colour
PRODUCTION BUDGET	USD 1,000
STUDENT PROJECT	Yes — Indus University
FIRST-TIME FILMMAKER	No
PRODUCTION COMPANY	Cinegma Films Productions
WRITER & DIRECTOR	Syed Asad Raza Abidi
PRODUCER	Dayyan Khalid
KEY CAST	Zuhair Zubair · Umeza Irfan
STATUS	Completed

WHO WE FOLLOW

KEY CHARACTERS

AYAN THE PAINTER

PLAYED BY ZUHAIR ZUBAIR

A man in his mid-thirties, caught between his pursuit of perfection and the emotional turmoil of his past. His once-passionate love for painting is now overshadowed by frustration and self-doubt. He is not cruel by nature; he is a person who has mistaken his standards for his identity, and who cannot separate a failed canvas from a failed self. Everything he refuses to look at in his own history ends up on the easel in front of him.

ZARA THE WIFE

PLAYED BY UMEZA IRFAN

A patient and understanding woman, also in her thirties, who quietly endures the tension in her relationship. She seeks to help her husband reconnect with the deeper meaning of art and of life, offering wisdom with calm and tenderness. Her steadiness is not passivity — she is the one person in the film who already knows what he is looking for, and her patience is a choice she keeps making long after it stops being easy.

THEMES

PERFECTIONISM · ARTISTIC BLOCK · MARRIAGE UNDER STRAIN · MEMORY & CHILDHOOD · SELF-WORTH · LETTING GO

At its centre the film asks a question that reaches well past the studio: what does a person destroy while trying to make something flawless? The painter's standards are not a craft problem but a defence, and the canvas he cannot finish is the one honest record of a life he has been refusing to look at. His wife is not an obstacle to the work — she is the part of it he has been painting over.

IN HIS OWN WORDS

DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

This film is about the search for perfection and the struggles we often hide. It's about finding beauty in the things we think are imperfect. The story is not just about painting — it's about understanding ourselves and the people around us. I hope this film makes you think and feel something that stays with you after watching.

"As a writer, I wanted this film to show the struggle between what we want and what we can accept. Through the painter's journey, I hope to explore how searching for perfection can lead us to understand ourselves better."

SYED ASAD RAZA ABIDI — WRITER & DIRECTOR

LOOK & FEEL

VISUAL APPROACH & TONE

TONE

INTROSPECTIVE · EMOTIONAL · TENSE · PHILOSOPHICAL · THOUGHT-PROVOKING · REFLECTIVE · INTIMATE · SUBTLE · COMPLEX

VISUAL REFERENCES

1975 — **MIRROR**
Dir. Andrei Tarkovsky
For the way memory intrudes on the present without announcing itself — childhood arriving in the middle of an adult crisis, unexplained and unresolved.

2019 — **PORTRAIT OF A LADY ON FIRE**
Dir. Céline Sciamma
For the charge between painter and subject, and for treating the act of looking as the central dramatic event rather than a backdrop to it.

2017 — **A GHOST STORY**
Dir. David Lowery
For patience — long, held frames that let a domestic space carry grief and distance without a line of dialogue to explain it.

APPROACH

The film is presented in a 1.33:1 frame — the squared-off ratio of a canvas rather than a screen. It is a deliberate constraint for a story about a man who cannot get an image right: every shot is bounded on all four sides, the way a painting is, and there is nowhere for either character to move out of view. Shot on a Sony FX3, the film keeps its world small and its camera close — a studio, a marriage, an unfinished canvas — and lets the composition carry what the two characters will not say to each other.

THE TEAM

CAST & KEY CREW

CAST

AYAN
ZUHAIR ZUBAIR

ZARA
UMEZA IRFAN

KEY CREW

WRITTEN & DIRECTED BY
SYED ASAD RAZA ABIDI

PRODUCED BY
DAYYAN KHALID

DIRECTOR OF PHOTOGRAPHY
GHAYAS UDDIN SIDDQUI

PRODUCTION DESIGNER
FAIZAN AHMED

PRODUCTION MANAGER
AMEER HAMZA

CAST CO-ORDINATOR
ZOHA MAJID

MAKE-UP
NARMEEN TALIB

END TITLES

FULL CREDITS

AYAN
ZUHAIR ZUBAIR

ZARA
UMEZA IRFAN

WRITTEN AND DIRECTED BY
SYED ASAD RAZA ABIDI

PRODUCED BY
DAYYAN KHALID

DIRECTOR OF PHOTOGRAPHY
GHAYAS UDDIN SIDDQUI

PRODUCTION DESIGNER
FAIZAN AHMED

PRODUCTION MANAGER
AMEER HAMZA

CAST CO-ORDINATOR
ZOHA MAJID

MAKE-UP
NARMEEN TALIB

SPECIAL THANKS

HISHAM MIRZA · FARAZ BAQIR · WAQEE RIAZ · MUHAMMAD USMAN · AYESHA SIDDUIQA · HASHIR BHATTI · RAMIS KHALID

A

CINEGMA FILMS

PRODUCTION

BEHIND THE FILM

THE PRODUCTION & PRESS ASSETS

ABOUT THE PRODUCTION

Portrait of Life is a Cinegma Films production, written and directed by Syed Asad Raza Abidi and produced by Dayyan Khalid. The film was shot in Pakistan in Urdu, on a Sony FX3, and completed on 2 June 2025 with a runtime of 11 minutes 34 seconds.

It was made as a student project at Indus University on a production budget of one thousand US dollars — a scale worth stating plainly, because almost everything on screen is the result of a small crew doing several jobs each and a cast of two carrying an entire film between them.

PRESS ASSETS

- **Key art / poster** — high-resolution files for print and web
- **Film stills** — available on request
- **Screener** — private link, available to press and festival programmers on request
- **Production company logo** — vector and transparent PNG

All press assets are available from Cinegma Films Productions using the contact details overleaf.

GET IN TOUCH

CONTACT

For press enquiries, screener access, festival programming, interview requests with the director, or high-resolution assets, please contact Cinegma Films Productions.

EMAIL

info@cinegmafilms.com

MOBILE

+92 344 180 5450

WEBSITE

cinegmafilms.com

PORTRAIT OF LIFE

PERFECTION FADES, BUT TRUE ART REMAINS.

© CINEGMA FILMS PRODUCTIONS — ALL RIGHTS RESERVED